STEMS & GROOVES

Pacing guide · 6 days

PACING

Teacher

Six class periods of about 53 minutes, as in my course plan: a learning day, three work days, a submission day and a presenting day. Foundation first, then Full Song. Each day's full plan is on pages 9–11.

DAY	FOCUS AND GOAL	MINUTE BLOCKS	DECK
DAY 1 Learning	**Learning + Foundation start** Every student has a stem downloaded, sections labeled, and an A pattern started.	0–5 · The stem, no drums 5–15 · Introduce the project 15–25 · Listen twice 25–48 · Markers + A pattern 48–53 · Save	Intro deck slides 1–9
DAY 2 Work day	**Working: Foundation** Foundation complete. Both patterns placed correctly. Mix adjusted.	0–5 · Quick check 5–45 · A, B, place 45–53 · Gain staging	Intro deck slides 10–12
DAY 3 Work day	**Transition workshop + Full Song start** At least two transitions built. Students understand the difference between the four types.	0–15 · Transition workshop 15–48 · Map + build 48–53 · Save	Intro deck slides 13–15
DAY 4 Work day	**Working: Full Song** All section changes have deliberate transitions. Mix adjusted. Project ready to submit.	0–53 · Full working day	Intro deck slides 16–17
DAY 5 Submit	**Submission + presentation prep** All projects submitted before Day 6.	0–20 · Finish + submit 20–53 · Early presentations	Intro deck slides 18–20
DAY 6 Present	**Presenting** Every student plays their full drum track alongside the stem; every student hears the professional skill they just used.	0–5 · Last submissions 5–53 · Presentations	Intro deck slides 21–22

STUDENT PAGES BY DAY ·

Day 1	Day 1 post (p. 15), project sheet (pp. 19–22), section map Part 1 (p. 18)
Day 2	Gain staging (p. 17)
Day 3	The four transitions (p. 16), section map Part 2 (p. 18), name that transition (p. 24)
Days 4–6	Checklist (p. 22) and rubric (p. 23)

MY LINE FOR THE WHOLE UNIT

"Never push anything into the red. It is almost always better to turn other things down." And before anything: listen first, then respond.

PREVIEW

STEMS & GROOVES

The four transitions

STUDENT

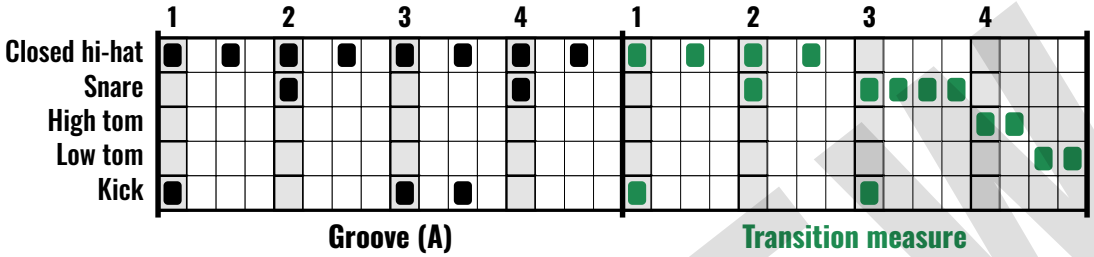
Reference

A transition is the moment between two sections where the drums signal that a change is coming. Each example shows one measure of the groove, then the transition measure (green) right before the new section. Each grid column is a sixteenth note; grey columns are the beats.

1 · DRUM FILL

a rhythmic variation in the last 1–2 measures that signals a change is coming.

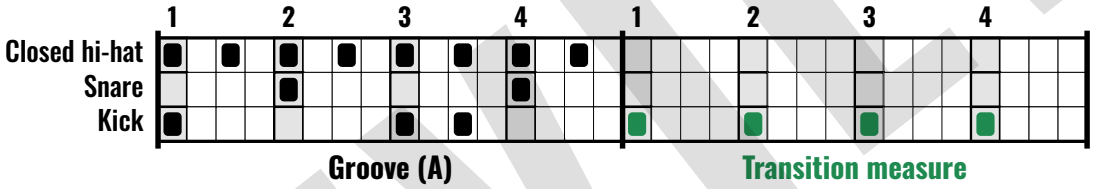
Use it: the classic: works almost anywhere, especially into a bigger section.



2 · BREAKDOWN

strip to one element (kick only, hi-hat only) before the new section hits.

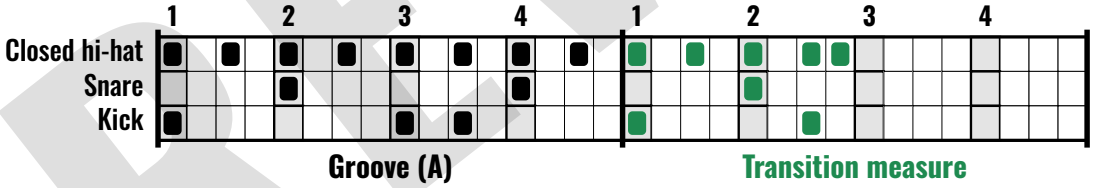
Use it: before a section that should hit harder, or as the music thins out.



3 · CUT

complete silence for 1–2 beats before the next section drops.

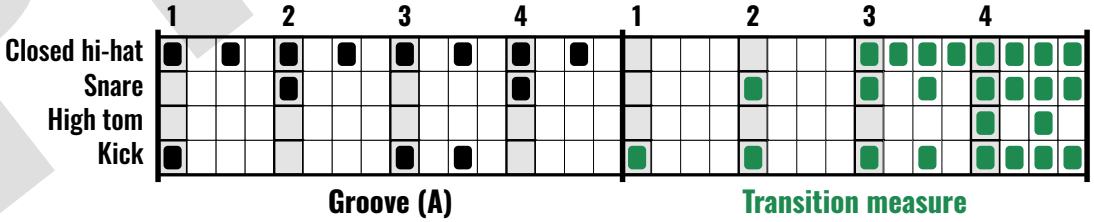
Use it: the most powerful and the easiest to do badly; a cut before a quiet verse.



4 · BUILD

add elements progressively in the last measure to increase energy into the change.

Use it: a build before a big chorus.



PREVIEW

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STEMS & GROOVES

Project sheet · requirements

STUDENT

Name _____ Date _____

REQUIREMENTS ·

PART 1 — FOUNDATION

- [ ] Choose one stem track from the Foundation folder on your class page
- [ ] Listen to the full track and identify at least two distinct sections (A and B) before building anything
- [ ] Write an A pattern: a drum groove that fits the feel of one section type
- [ ] Write a B pattern: a drum groove that clearly contrasts with A in feel, energy, or rhythm
- [ ] Place patterns correctly so they follow the section changes in the track
- [ ] Minimum 3 layers per pattern (kick, snare, hi-hat at minimum)
- [ ] All track volumes adjusted so nothing clips and every element is audible
- [ ] Project named correctly: “Your Name - Foundation”
- [ ] Exported as MP3 and .zip (compressed .logicx file) and submitted via your class page before presenting

PART 2 — FULL SONG

- [ ] Using a new Full Song stem from your class page, identify every section change in the track
- [ ] At each section change, add a deliberate transition using one of the four options: drum fill, breakdown, cut, or build
- [ ] Every section change must have a transition… no pattern can simply loop through a boundary without acknowledgment
- [ ] At least two different transition types must be used across the full track
- [ ] Transitions should feel appropriate to the music… a cut before a quiet verse, a build before a big chorus
- [ ] All track volumes and panning adjusted… mix serves the stem, not the other way around
- [ ] Project named correctly: “Your Name - Full Song”
- [ ] Exported as MP3 and .zip (compressed .logicx file) and submitted via your class page before presenting

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STEMS & GROOVES — RUBRIC

Digital Music Production 1 · Unit 2 · /25

Each category is scored from 2 to 5.

Category	2	3	4	5	Score
FOUNDATIONS	A and B patterns are nearly identical. Drums do not respond to the stem or follow its sections.	A/B distinction exists but contrast is minimal. Patterns placed but feel independent of the music.	A and B patterns clearly contrast in feel or energy. Patterns follow section changes in the stem.	A and B patterns have distinct personalities and serve the music at every moment. Placement is precise and intentional.	
FULL SONG	No deliberate transitions. Patterns loop through section boundaries without acknowledgment.	Some section changes acknowledged but transitions feel accidental or mismatched to the music.	All section changes have a deliberate transition. At least two different transition types used.	Every transition feels inevitable - the right type chosen for each moment. The music earns each section change.	
TECHNICAL SKILL / DAW USE	Significant workflow errors. Pattern regions placed incorrectly or step sequencer used with major confusion.	Patterns placed but some section changes missed or misaligned. Some workflow confusion.	Patterns correctly placed across all section changes. Step sequencer used with confidence.	64-step mode used for transition detail. Pattern regions managed cleanly. Workflow is confident and organized.	
GAIN STAGING & MIX	No meaningful volume adjustments. Drum track overwhelms or is buried under the stem.	Some volume adjustment but mix is unbalanced. Drums compete with the stem rather than supporting it.	Volumes adjusted so drums and stem coexist. Nothing is clipping. Mix is mostly appropriate.	Drum track sits perfectly in relation to the stem. Every element is audible. Nothing clips. Mix feels like one cohesive piece of music.	
DOCUMENTATION & PRESENTATION	Project not submitted or not presented.	Project submitted late or named incorrectly. Presentation made with minimal engagement.	Project named correctly and submitted. Presentation made. Padlet questions posted.	Project correctly named, submitted on time. Confident presentation. Three thoughtful Padlet questions posted.	
				TOTAL	**/ 25**

MY FAVORITE TRANSITION, AND WHY...

TEACHER COMMENTS

PREVIEW

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